

Sales Training Debrief — Session 15

Pitch High. Read the Room. Hold the Line.

Sales training led by Corie Dawson, Director · Monday 25 May 2026 · Marketing Sweet

1. Profit is king, not turnover

The session opened with a barrister doing roughly \$1.3M in annual turnover. The instinctive read was: that's the number to pitch against. Wrong. Turnover is gross. What matters is what hits his bank account after he pays himself, his costs, and his lifestyle.

Working it through: hourly rate × billable hours × five days × fifty-two weeks gives turnover. Strip out his living expenses and he's sitting on six figures of disposable profit. That number is the capacity to spend — and the lens through which every pitch should be sized.

"You're thinking turnover is king. Profit is king. He's making more in a week than the website costs him for the year — why are you pitching cheap?"

The discipline:

- On the prep sheet for every meeting: turnover, estimated overheads, estimated profit. Don't skip the third column.
- Size the pitch to the profit, not the revenue. A high-margin operator with low overheads has spending power that a high-revenue, low-margin business does not.
- If a deal lands inside their weekly take-home, you're pitching too low. Use that as a self-check before walking in.

2. Read the room — build the buyer profile sheet

Same English, different dialects. A flashy Sydney barrister hears differently to a utilitarian regional excavation owner. Same product, same words won't land for both. The rep's job is to identify which dialect this buyer speaks before the pitch starts.

The profile sheet should sit at the top of every meeting prep:

DATA TO CAPTURE	WHY IT MATTERS
Industry and years in business	Sets the language register and the sophistication of objections.
Location (capital vs regional)	City buyers care about prestige; regional buyers care about practicality.
Number of staff + turnover	Inputs into the profit estimate that sizes the pitch.
Estimated profit	The real spending capacity. Pitch to this, not turnover.
Persona — flashy or utilitarian	Determines whether you sell looks/credibility or function/value.
Big ego or small ego	Big ego = sell exclusivity. Small ego = sell certainty

DATA TO CAPTURE	WHY IT MATTERS
	and simplicity.
Decision-maker or not	If they're not the DM, your job is to arm them for the conversation.

Adjectives to circle on the sheet: flashy, down-to-earth, value-seeker, status-seeker, time-poor, hands-on, sceptical, eager. Once you've circled the right ones, the pitch writes itself.

3. Pitch high — let them choke, let them bring you down

Going in low is the most common pricing mistake. Cheap pitches send the signal that you've misread the buyer — they look at you and think “wrong company.” The opposite move — anchor high, then come down — leaves room to negotiate and lets the buyer feel like they earned the deal.

■ *“Go in as high as you can, and let him choke on it for a bit. Let him bring you down.”*

The anchor ladder in practice:

1. Open with the upper-mid option. Stretch the buyer's expectation.
2. Hold the line. If they push, reluctantly mention the option underneath.
3. If they push again, retreat to a smaller package — but never the smallest unless they've forced you all the way down.
4. Use the words “most clients of your caliber go for X” to anchor at the top. Then “start off small” to make the middle option feel like a relief.

Watch-outs:

- Don't wear the moral compass for the buyer. They have a financial manager — that's not your job. Your job is to recommend what serves them and the business.
- The phrase “only \$X” is permission language — for example, “only 400 bucks a month, that's chump change for a guy like you.”
- If the deal lands inside what the buyer would lose in a single mishandled lead, the price isn't the problem — the framing of the price is.

4. Speak their dialect — flashy vs utilitarian

Two buyers can have identical turnover and identical bank balances and buy in totally different ways. The flashy buyer values status, prestige, and looking the part. The utilitarian buyer values function, reliability, and not being ripped off. Mis-pitching the dialect kills the deal even when the product is right.

FLASHY BUYER	UTILITARIAN BUYER
Sell looks, credibility, prestige	Sell function, process, certainty
“Be the best in your industry online”	“Your website is a silent winner or silent killer”
Talk about top-tier competitors	Talk about lost leads and missed referrals

FLASHY BUYER	UTILITARIAN BUYER
Show the visual quality of the product	Show the process map and support ticketing system
Big-ticket items feel right, not wrong	Small, justified spend with clear ROI
Drives a premium car, wears the name	Drives the work ute, no-frills phone
Buys the brand — Rolex, Hugo Boss	Buys the spec — off the rack, fit-for-purpose

How to identify which dialect you're in within the first five minutes of a meeting:

- Listen for what they brag about. Possessions? They're flashy. Achievements or longevity? They're utilitarian.
- Watch what they pull out — the watch, the phone, the laptop. The objects tell you the dialect.
- Ask about a recent purchase decision. The framing they use is the framing they'll use to evaluate your pitch.

5. Show, don't tell — specific evidence beats generic claims

Buyers tune out the moment a generic claim hits the room. “We have great customer service” means nothing. Every competitor says it. The fix is to replace every generic claim with a specific, demonstrable piece of evidence the buyer can picture.

“You say ‘we have great customer service.’ That’s what the last guy said. You need to say ‘we run a support ticketing system — here’s how it works.’”

The reframe — generic to specific:

GENERIC (DON'T)	SPECIFIC (DO)
“We have an experienced team”	“Taylor leads your build — over a decade designing websites”
“We have great customer service”	“We run a support ticketing system with response-time metrics”
“We have a clear process”	“There's a 170-point checklist behind every build — here it is on screen”
“We deliver quality”	“Here are three competitors of yours. This is them, and through our process, this is what you'd look like”
“We're responsive”	“Send a support ticket at 2am — you get a callback or email reply by the morning”

Operating principle: if your competitor would say the same sentence, the sentence is generic. Add the specific until they couldn't.

The dish, not the restaurant:

"You don't say 'the restaurant has good food.' You say 'you've got to try the duck.' Hone in on the dish. Once you're on the dish, it's no longer about the restaurant."

6. The narrative opener — asymmetric questions

Every meeting should open with an asymmetric question — one where any answer the buyer gives leads to the same outcome for you. The session's example: "Just out of interest, how are you finding the changes with the economy?"

Why it works:

5. If they say business is booming → "Great, then this is the perfect moment to invest in your visibility before competitors catch on."
6. If they say things are slow → "That's exactly the reason for my call. A lot of clients in your space are saying the same thing."
7. If they say it doesn't affect them → "That's exactly why you can afford to get in front now while others are pulling back."

"It's an asymmetric comment. It has no downside. Whatever they say, the next sentence is the same: 'that's the reason for my call.'"

Pre-requisites for the move:

- Know the actual narrative. Read the news. Know what the budget changed, what fuel prices are doing, what the rate environment looks like. Buyers can smell unprepared.
- Use "just out of interest" as the power phrase. It removes the salesperson edge and creates space for the buyer to talk.
- Listen to the answer. If they get passionate, totally agree — even if you don't. People buy from people they feel agreed-with.

7. Hold the line — reluctance sells

The biggest credibility leak in the room is the rep who swivels too fast. The buyer says "that's a bit much," and within five seconds the rep has dropped the price, dropped the package, or moved to the alternative option. That movement reads as desperation.

"The quicker you swivel, the less credibility you have. You've got a big problem with credibility — massive — because you're too movable."

Holding the line in practice:

- Pitch the recommended package and stay there. If pushed, reluctantly mention an alternative — "If you really want to, there's another option, but I wouldn't recommend it."
- Discouraging the alternative makes the buyer want it more. This is the duck on the menu and the Krispy Kreme principle — exclusivity, not availability, drives desire.
- Use "most clients prefer X because..." to keep the recommendation gravity on the right product. Pack animals follow the herd.

The duck principle:

“If I tell you ‘don’t get the duck, it’s terrible,’ what do you want to do? Try the duck. That’s human nature. Discouraging it triggers desire.”

8. The out-in dance — pressure release into pressure

Closing is a rhythm, not a push. The rep who goes straight for the close on day one reads as desperate — like getting begged into bed on a first date. The fix is the in-out-in-out dance: relieve pressure, apply pressure, relieve again, apply again.

The choreography:

8. Pitch the product. Hold the line on the price.
9. Pivot to pressure-release: “Look, you don’t have to decide today, you’ve got heaps of time.”
10. Re-introduce a soft incentive: “If you can make a decision by Wednesday, I can include the first two months hosting at no extra cost.”
11. Pull back again: “No pressure either way — if you need more time, just let me know tomorrow.”
12. Close: “We’ve done the hard part. All I need is the deposit to lock it in.”

“You’re not literally there to pressure him. You’re there to give him an opportunity to make a decision. The dance is what makes the opportunity feel like his idea.”

Why the dance works:

- Buyers expect pressure. When you remove it, they relax — and start moving toward you on their own.
- The incentive lands differently after pressure-release. It feels like a gift, not a manipulation.
- Either answer is useful. If they take the incentive, you have the deal. If they don’t, you’ve revealed they were never going to buy and you’ve protected your time.

9. Active listening + the “most people” frame

Two small techniques that compound across the call. Both are about making the buyer feel heard and normal — pack animals don’t want to be the only one doing something.

Active listening — the regurgitation move:

- Repeat their words back, slightly reframed. “Look, I understand — you’ve built a 17-year business on referrals, you’ve never done marketing, and the website hasn’t been a priority.”
- The proof of listening unlocks them. The pitch that follows lands inside a conversation, not on top of one.
- Skip this step and you sound like you’re reading off a page. Reps who don’t regurgitate get accused of running a script — because they are.

The “most people” frame:

- “Most clients in your space go for...” — anchors the recommendation in social proof.

- “Most” is reassuring; “all” triggers alarms. Pack animals want to follow the herd, but they don’t want to be told they have no choice.
- Use it in pricing (“most go for the upper-mid”), in process (“most prefer monthly”), in timing (“most decide within the week”).

The restaurant test:

“You go to a restaurant where you can’t read the menu. You ask the waiter. He says ‘most people order the duck.’ How does that make you feel? Comfortable. That’s the power of ‘most’.”

10. Fewer, deeper appointments — not more, shallower

Pad the day with seven shallow meetings and you get the close rate that comes with shallow meetings. The fix is the opposite: three to four properly scoped appointments, with enough room around each one to run the full dance.

The two-hour window principle:

- Allow up to two hours per pitch. Nesting in for the close is part of the work, not a deviation from it.
- If three appointments don’t roll up, that time is not lost — it’s phone time, or training time. Both compound.
- The leader who sees the team pick up the phones when meetings drop sees leadership. That’s the broadcast you want on the floor.

“You’re not closing two because you’ve got seven appointments. You’re closing two because you’ve got seven shallow appointments. Three deep ones, you close three.”

11. Action items this week

13. Add a profit column to every prep sheet. Calculate it before walking into any meeting.
14. Add a persona row — flashy/utilitarian, big-ego/small-ego — and circle the right adjectives before each pitch.
15. Anchor the pitch at upper-mid. Stop opening with the cheapest option.
16. Replace every generic claim in your pitch with a specific piece of evidence. Write the new version on a card.
17. Open every meeting with an asymmetric question. Have two ready before you walk in.
18. Read the news before every day of pitching. Know the narrative.
19. Practice the out-in dance on at least one call this week. Notice what shifts.
20. Cap the day at four appointments. Block two hours around each.
21. Active-listen at the top of every pitch — regurgitate three things the buyer told you in lead-gen.

THE ONE-LINER Profit not turnover. Read the room. Pitch high, hold the line. Dance the pressure. Most people do.